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Political Economy of Housing in Chile

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Through the lens of political economy, this book positions housing as a key factor in understanding social inequality. It does so by drawing on rich empirical evidence from the case of the Chilean housing market.

This book provides insights on the articulation between real estate development, housing provision and social inequality based on applied urban economics analyses that illustrate the contradictions of neoliberal urbanism through the case of Chile. For neoliberal urbanism, the good city is not equal for all, it is based on the principle of profitability and benefits from segregation to make capital investment more efficient. The chapters of this book expose how these processes are generated by a political system that allows them rather than by the invisible hand of the market.

The book will be of interest to graduate students in urban studies, urban planning, sociology and urban geography. It will also appeal to decision-makers and also to actors in the real estate market seeking to perfect the social benefits of their professional activities, aspiring to generate more egalitarian and just cities.

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Preface

This book articulates the problem of the housing crisis with the political economy in order to advance the complexity of a social problem of great global relevance, broadening its purely operational scope, which refers to the material production of housing. The aim of the book is to discuss the scope of housing in terms of the integral planning of the state, the nation and economic relations. Housing is a result of political action, and as such, its scope goes far beyond architects, planners or urban planners to incorporate actors as diverse as investors in stock exchanges to presidents of a central bank. If the housing problem has not found lasting solutions in much of the world, it may be because of its prioritisation, as a problem of public interest is mainly sectoral rather than a comprehensive matter affecting the many. In our view, the housing problem cannot be solved only with design, politics or economics, but with all of them at the same time, interrelated, and by incorporating the knowledge of other disciplinary fields ranging from anthropology to social work. If space is a result of social relations, housing is possibly the most social of all spaces.

The book we present is the result of years of joint work by a group of authors in different academic instances. Our reflections are situated in Chile, where we have been part of a real struggle to broaden the decision-making frameworks that affect the process of producing decent housing for the population. In our work as researchers, we often come across findings that deserve to be heard by decision-makers. However, neither the findings nor the researchers themselves have the same information dissemination apparatus as the actors who have vested interests in the field. A scientific article does not carry the same weight as several press releases in the eyes of decision-makers, and often, having an open platform in the media allows scientific findings to be disqualified without counterweight. On the other hand, researchers tend to fall into the innocence of believing that findings alone, backed by science, should have enough weight of their own to impute the arguments of an industry that defends its business. This permissive

innocence often allows the findings to fail to influence housing policy, which is our focus of study. But we have learned from both failures and achievements. One of the main lessons learned is that the housing problem is a case of political economy, according to a study on inequality that arises from productive and commercial relations with the state and society. This book seeks, precisely, to share the process that led to this learning.

The authors have gathered findings that allow us to support that the housing problem is a matter of political economy. We have reported how energy poverty is reflected in housing design and production processes, emphasising that the real estate industry needs to adapt its ways of producing for the urgencies of climate change. We have also raised the importance of improving the mechanisms for measuring socio-territorial realities, so that the authorities understand the future value of this data in designing public policies. We have also produced evidence that indicates the contradictions of the housing market and how its results are unattainable for many households that do not have secure access to housing. Framing these discussions in a political economy book allows us to broadly share how our research findings align with a broader discussion of structural inequality in neoliberalised nations.

In 2020, we launched a book in Chile that served as a general basis for this book. At that time, the discussion we developed was much more focused on the local problem. With the pandemic years of the new coronavirus and its consequent social crisis, we saw how our findings could be useful in other nations, where the ways of understanding the housing problem could be aligned with the issues that arise in Chile. To this, we added that Chile is a global outlier, being the first nation where a neoliberal political economy model was imposed in 1975 under the dictatorial regime of Augusto Pinochet, advised by the Chicago Boys and Milton Friedman himself. Chile was the guinea pig for the neoliberal experiment that was later implemented in a lot of places around the world. Therefore, as an atypical case of neoliberalism, almost caricatured, the lessons that emerge from its contradictions can be useful in other nations where neoliberalism is also in crisis. In this book, we share applicable and replicable methodological approaches with data that can be used in other countries to compare experiences and review the scope of the political economy of housing in each specific local reality. In addition, in the 2020 book, we knew little of the transcendental effects that the social explosion in Chile would have, and this book did not know the importance the new coronavirus would have in revealing the importance of housing but from the disciplines of public health, thereby broadening the scope of the problem that at that time seemed very sectoral, especially in terms of urban planning disciplines.

We have tried to develop a didactic book, avoiding technicalities and focusing on how the results speak to the problem of inequality from the analysis of housing. In essence, this is a book that uses housing to explain one of the possible origins of inequality: the fair distribution of territory and the absence of the right to the city. As we write this book, Chile is debating the approval of a new Political Constitution of the Republic, drafted for the first time in history by a democratically elected, parity-based and socially diverse collegiate body. This new constitutional text enshrines the right to housing and the right to the city. If this constitution is implemented, this book could serve to identify factors in the housing production process that facilitate the reproduction of inequality in order to generate solutions from the new rights-based approach.



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1 Introduction

The production and reproduction of space are profoundly ideological/political events. Space is not merely an inert substance deployed by designers. Overall, urban planning adjudicates the process as the agent of state interventionism, on behalf of social reproduction, capital accumulation and the circulation of commodities. Therefore, it is centrally involved in the management of a key factor of production, namely land (and, as such, in the generation of land rent, profit and surplus value).

Alexander Cuthbert, 2011¹

The process of urban development is profoundly ideological. Dressing up the disciplines dedicated to the city in scientific suits, with an aspiration to develop results in an apolitical, ideology-free way, is a mistake of origin. It fails to recognise that space, and especially the city, is produced politically. Disputes, impositions, violence, community organisation, resistance and agreements shape-built space. Under this premise, in our understanding, there is no technocracy without ideologies, given that technique is always inscribed in epistemological frameworks that generate interpretations marked by the authors of each design, originating in specific ontological positions. In other words, subjectivity is also part of the design of the methods used in urban studies. This may be a truism in some parts of the world, where science is indeed closer to decision-makers, but we who write from South America know that it is a necessary distinction. So, urbanism, like many other disciplinary fields, allows us to justify approaches to urban productive processes in search of generating convictions and certainties about how to operate in the city, but it serves specific purposes and, therefore, has a strong ideological component at its root. In Chile, the basic ideology of urban planning since its neoliberalisation began in 1976 (with the liberalisation of taxes on construction production processes) is to seek mechanisms that validate decision-making based on the profitability (economic and

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social) of urban transformations. However, this is not exclusive to Chile, although it is one of the few places in the world where the phenomenon has been widely studied over 40 years and in the case of Santiago, it is more visible and therefore more interesting to analyse. Studying the processes of housing production in Chile is not so different from studying its socio-economic history. Peggy Deamer puts it clearly: Since the production of architecture and cities requires immense amounts of capital that articulate the public, the private and the social, the history of cities is in large part the history of capitalism itself.² Similarly, we will understand the neoliberal model in the sense proposed by David Harvey: Incubated during the crisis of the 1970s, masked under a “thick layer of rhetoric about individual freedom, personal responsibility, the virtues of privatisation, free markets and free trade”, and which in practice legitimised “draconian policies aimed at restoring and consolidating the power of the capitalist class”.³

It is for this reason that the book we present here is so relevant for the interpretation of history in Chile, given that it uses data and records from 2019, a key year in setting a different course from the turbo-capitalism to which we have been exposed since 1975. It is an important date, and although we do not know the future yet, the data indicate that many things will change from now on, including the political economy of housing and the disciplinary ethics that shape it. Referring to the national contingency, Sebastian Edwards, a renowned academic at the University of California (UCLA), said, “the neoliberal experiment is completely dead”.⁴

In the early hours of Friday 15 November 2019, Congress signed the agreement to initiate a new constituent process to be plebiscite in April 2020. This book was completed on the same Friday. In seeking to make the ideology of this text transparent, we establish that we are critical of the processes that generate socio-spatial inequality and seek to understand how these end up benefiting a few at the expense of many others. Thus, we are inclined towards an urban ontology influenced by spatial justice thinking derived from the critical urbanism advocated by Jane Jacobs, Susan Fainstein, David Harvey, Raquel Rolnik and mostly, the principles of Henri Lefebvre’s Right to the City. However, we also believe that contradictions underlie the very methodologies of neoliberal urbanism that attempt to justify its decision-making. It is for this reason that, from critical urbanism as an interpretative framework, we use the tools of neoliberal urbanism to study its conditions and review, with its own methods of validation, the fissures that emerge and materialise in conflictive socio-spatial phenomena. Above all, as a major ethical framework, we try to situate ourselves within the charter of human rights as a referential platform for our reflections. We believe that housing needs special attention from this perspective in the Chilean context.

Housing is a human right. It sounds like a slogan, but there is no chance of a good life without access to safe, healthy, well-designed and good quality housing. Homelessness is the lack of a bed, a bathroom, a kitchen, access to drinking water, shelter, privacy—the material certainty of the old saying “having somewhere to drop dead”. The horrifying thing is that currently in Chile, without money, there is nowhere to drop dead. Moreover, legislatively, it is a human right because it is suggested by the United Nations, the planetary body in charge of safeguarding respect for human rights. In this respect, Leilani Farha, special rapporteur on housing for this organisation, after learning about the Chilean reality in terms of the right to housing, recommended that the State of Chile “redouble its efforts to diversify the housing model, ensuring that the creation of housing does not depend solely on private developers and ensure that families are not obliged to obtain a mortgage”.⁵ This accurate recommendation highlights one of the main problems facing the nation in ensuring the human right to housing: the privatisation of its allocation mechanisms and financialisation.

Housing in Chile is a private property rather than a right, and as such, it is traded commercially. In the current conditions of financialisation of everyday life, housing, as private property, has become a long-term fixed income financial asset. In other words, housing is used to invest and generate capital as its value increases over time. This financial function of housing is displacing its use function—today it is more important that housing is profitable than it is of good quality. An example of this is how the elemental proposal was interpreted to privilege the location of social housing and thus maximise resources to obtain better land instead of better housing.⁶ While the architectural world paid a lot of attention to the design driven by the versatile skills of the elemental team, the decision-makers valued more that the design be in more central urban sectors to improve added value. In other words, they did not care as much about liveability as they did about its value increasing over time. This discourse permeated into other modes of urban production, and nowadays, the construction of 17 m² flats—known as nano-apartments—is beginning to be validated as a possibility to live close to the centre and, therefore, with good added value. This is aberrant, but it follows the neoliberal logic of *Homo economicus*, in which human decisions are assumed to be based on economic views of problems and the decisions are rational. Unfortunately, while the process of acquiring a home can indeed be approached from an economic perspective, everyday life does not fit into such calculations. Its fundamental social role means that housing is not a matter for architects interested in its functionality or economists interested in its profitability, but is a problem that concerns all social strata, including health—ensured by an adequate design to avoid respiratory diseases—so that alienation processes do not occur due to models of housing that are not

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very inclusive to its technical, sustainable, legislative and political qualities, among many other aspects in which housing is key. However, in the national context—which is far from idealism—we have to analyse housing as an economic element, understand its complexity, and with it, deconstruct it to see if its productive processes and uses can be humanised. This is why we speak of the political economy of housing.

For David Ricardo, one of the fathers of political economy, economic relations are in themselves decisional and therefore, they fulfil a political function. This is why it is so relevant when it comes to understanding productive processes as well as such material aspects such as the formation of prices, rents, and values. For his part, Karl Marx states that value and price are formed as a consequence of a set of social relations that develop according to what the productive structures of society allow, which are created and formed according to the interests of the capitalist or, in this case, of the actors in the productive cycle with the greatest decision-making power. In Chile, it would be equivalent to what Gabriel Salazar has called the “civil political class” and the “speculative mercantile class”.⁷ So, to define the intellectual position from which this work is developed, we will understand political economy as the study of production and exchange in relation to legislative aspects, market, government, state and consumers (once citizens) from a critical perspective of income distribution, political-economic opportunities and aspects related to wealth. The political economy of housing is the study of the factors that explain its accessibility or inaccessibility, seeking to ensure its correct allocation to households from the market, the state and the tools provided by public policy. In the particular case of Chile, this study of the political economy of housing stems from the crisis of access that the country is experiencing. Although it is an issue that has been around for some time in academic circles, it gained particular notoriety a few months ago when it was mentioned publicly by the Chilean Chamber of Construction (Cámara Chilena de la Construcción). Indeed, in a meeting before authorities and businessmen—including the President of the Republic, Sebastián Piñera—the president of the trade union organisation, Patricio Donoso, declared, “I am not exaggerating if I say that we are facing a crisis of access to housing that is soon to turn into a social crisis”.⁸ And then, the social outburst that began on 18 October 2019 only confirmed it, since one of its declared causes was the high cost of living, where housing is the heaviest element.

The book we present here compiles a set of in-depth studies on the political economy of housing, trying to explain why it has become inaccessible and testing some ways to reverse this condition. Part of these chapters and their conclusions have already been presented in articles in specialised journals, book chapters and articles published in the prestigious Chilean media

called *CIPER* (Centro de Investigación Periodística). This academic production has been developed within the Centro de Producción del Espacio of the Universidad de Las Américas and the Centro de Desarrollo Urbano Sustentable (CEDEUS) of the Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile. Thus, the studies presented in this text seek to dispute with scientifically developed data that the housing market in Chile is imperfect and requires substantial improvements in order to advance towards the human right to housing.

The first chapter of the book discusses the context of housing in Chile, marked by its Political Constitution, where housing as such is not present in the text and it is treated only as private property. The second part explores the relationship between the cost of living in Chile's cities and household income—which is largely the justification for this study—given that housing is the most significant household expense and has now become unaffordable for large portions of the population. A third part sets out the arguments most commonly used to explain high housing prices by academics and the business community. The fourth part puts forward one of our hypotheses based on concrete data: housing is unaffordable because it has become a business that aims at profitability rather than habitability. The fifth part explores this idea further and discusses how housing has become a long-term fixed income financial asset, more profitable than other financial instruments and tremendously competitive for investors, thus breaking its use value and more strongly embracing its exchange value as the main criterion when deciding where to invest in housing and how to design it. In the sixth part, we extend a hypothesis on the importance of location as a key factor in defining housing prices and how this impacts social segregation. Towards the end, we propose a series of measures based on the necessary recognition of the social role of urban land and the importance of having an active state system of housing provision, along with strict regulatory frameworks for private residence, ensuring its fair price and high quality. This last part is based on international cases that could be applied in Chile. Finally, we develop a set of reflections and conclusions that seek to feed the upcoming debate on a new Constitution and the opportunities that open up from this space to rethink our cities.

Notes

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- 6 A reflection on this extra-disciplinary understanding is developed by journalist Hector Cossio in *El Mostrador* (<http://shorturl.at/vCUW1>) and the Hyatt Foundation itself in the statement of the arguments for awarding Aravena the Pritzker Prize: So-called incremental housing allows social housing to be built on land that is more expensive but closer to economic opportunities and gives residents a sense of personal investment. At: www.pritzkerprize.com/announcement-ale-jan-dro-ara-ve-na.
- 7 Salazar, Gabriel Salazar, *La enervante levedad historica de la clase politica civil (Chile 1900–1973)* (Santiago: Debate, 2015); Gabriel Salazar, *Historia de la acumulación capitalista en Chile (apuntes de clases)* (Santiago: LOM Ediciones, 2003).
- 8 *Pulse*. Construcción advierte riesgo de crisis social por creciente costo de las viviendas. *La Tercera Pulso*, 10 May 2019.

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